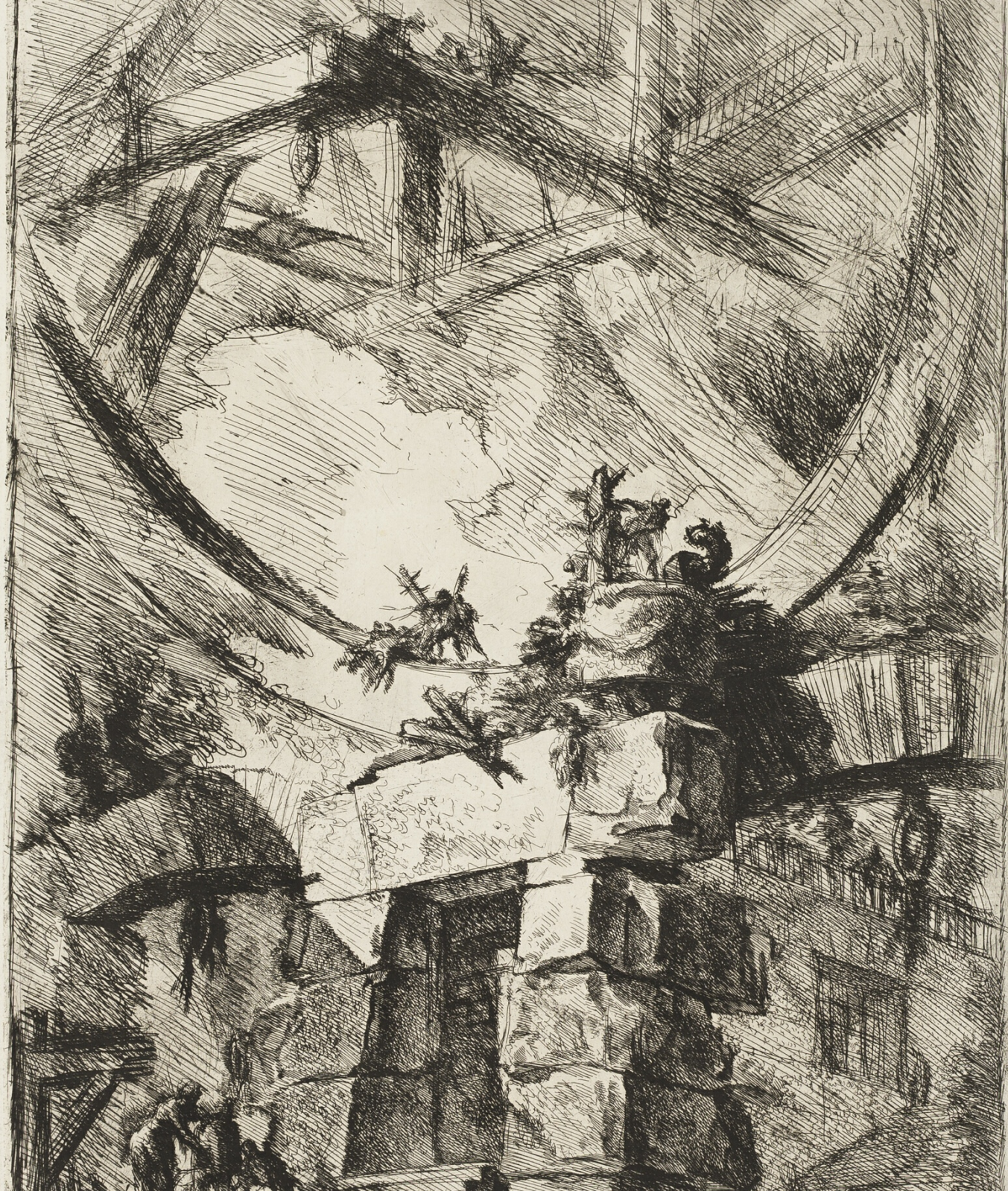




The Birds and Other Games

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In my dreams I can't escape the grim, deathly silence pinning us to the side of the metal cliff, the thousand foot drop to the industrial wasteland below. Sucking at the last of the oxygen stores, flesh, muscle, nonvital organs shrunken, blackened and shriveled, cannibalized to finance a few more beats of the heart, a few more delirious twitches of the synapses. Rotting corpses, ribcages torn apart hurriedly, the putrid taste of raw tendons, lymph nodes, veins, nourished by more sulfur than air in their final days.

I roll over in my nest of trash, careful not to wake any of the other vagrants laying about. I feel a sharp twang splitting between my brain lobes, opening up into a deeper ache that sinks and comes to rest in my brain stem. The sun above is engorged by its own reflection, radiation splintering through the pastel parchment sky.

A hologram appears in my mind's eye, translucent words with accompanying narration etched directly into my stream of consciousness. The ache intensifies as my vagus nerve heats and grows inflamed, pressing into my spine and skull.

You are awake. Perform the computation or return to rest state.

I feel a tap on my shoulder, which I pretend not to notice, and then a sharp jab. I sigh and reach down to pull a jagged blade from my sock, spinning around in one movement and slicing open a shallow wound on the side of Rustfinger's neck.

"Fucking fuck," he hisses as he jolts up from his crouched stance behind me, a splurt of blood escorting an encyclopedia's worth of disease to the dirt with a resigned splatter. He rips off his backpack and rummages frantically, pulling out a dirty roll of toilet paper and a ziploc bag, grey with filth and dust, wraps his neck unceremoniously, and crouching again, scrapes the mixture of blood, dirt and garbage runoff into the bag. I nod - labs will pay for these samples in the off chance of inspiring their devious machines to dream up some bioweapon even more lethal than currently available. It turns out that the randomness in the biochemistry of a junkie - or better yet, the biochemistry of the creepy-crawlies piggybacking on a junkie - is difficult to replicate in a controlled setting, and can sometimes help to perturb comfortable discovery models away from cheap local equilibria. Why do I know all of this? That's a story for another time.

"The fuck was that for?" Rustfinger mutters at me, remembering he should at least pretend to be upset. Really, we both know the rules and consequences. I glance down at my blade and back up at the man's eyes, sharp, darting, sunken into a weathered face, stumpy jaw and hollowed cheeks, patches of beard and greasy tousled hair singed by the sun, and he looks away, the tension falling out of his frame.

"Look, mama, I thought maybe we could play the game together today," he starts again, rubbing his eyes. "It's just the scraps are barely getting me through the night, and I'm burning more and more worms just to stay alive, pretty soon won't be nun' left of m-"

"What's that got to do with me?" I interrupt.

"C'mon, bitch," he erupts, bashfulness giving way to irritation. "You know goddamn well you got enough coin to get your fix for the next week and still go 'n get some fuckin' pussy after... or whatever the fuck you do."

"I'm not a fuckin' charity, rust. I put my birds to work, same as you."

I turn around to get back to the game, but again I feel Rustfinger's metal stumps prodding my shoulder insistently. At some level I register that something is off - Rust is stupid, but not this stupid. I brush his hand off me and swivel to look at him again. There is an urgency in his eyes, a searching desperation, that I must have missed before. I stay silent, giving him permission to continue.

"You put the work in to get your worms all wet for the birds, must've been hell... I'm not tryn' take that from you or nun'." He pauses intentionally, his eyes wide and gaze piercing, screaming something I can't hear. Alarm bells are ringing now. My ability and willingness to wield violence is the only thing stopping Rustfinger from cracking open my skull and fishing the birds right out of my brain soup - there is no respect for training or merit in the underworld. Anything that reeks of the meritocratic bullshit the Gluttons use to justify their control of the machines is rejected around here with the religious fervor of the old evangelicals. I keep my birds because of my blade, and the Gluttons keep their machines because of the drones we (shortsightedly) built for them, plain and simple.

"I'll give you a better split if you need, seventy-thirty, hell eighty-tw-"

"Alright, alright, just this once," I interject. Whatever he's trying to get me into, I get the sense it's too late to get away from. Besides, if my hunch is off and this is just about the money, Rustfinger is not wrong that I can afford to split the reward today, which is essentially what he's asking for. We both know that if one of us solves the puzzle, it's me.

Relieved, Rustfinger plops down cross-legged next to me, and we both mentally navigate through the steps to initiate the game. I feel the birds firing up, pulsing quickly in strange, coordinated patterns, finding, squeezing and stunning any organizational pathways in my neurons that might feel like agency. As I slip away, Rust jabs me with a needle, and I feel the good shit flowing into my veins.

"What... are you doing?" I manage to squeeze out, fighting the birds to coordinate my brain cells and form the words. Rustfinger looks apologetic, but it's too late for an explanation. He places his copper prosthetic on the center of my head, his eyes roll back and he slumps over. I twitch, trying to inch away, but the birds are too strong now.

Minimize your energy.

We are everywhere at once, spread like water, vibrating, flickering. We form the surface of a torus, but stretched to the point of snapping along one meridian, compressed all together along the opposite, and smoothly interpolating between these extremes. Our configuration is twisted into a figure eight, so that we cross over ourselves away from the extremal meridians. We want to untangle, to decompress and release the tension all at once, but those movements push and pull along the folded cross incompatibly. We've never been stuck like this before, and a jumbled, anxious pattern ripples through us. There is a tearing feeling, and suddenly we are either near the folded cross or we are smooth, but never both, two entities cut out from the whole, all of us falling endlessly, forever towards infinity. A sharp network of signals flashes between us, and a wall materializes that we curve up towards and glue ourselves to. The wall collapses to a point, and we are held together again. The folded cross jiggles and snaps apart into two surfaces, we swivel around and fuse together, stabilizing. Another grid of connection lights up, and we pour into a higher dimensional space, bending and squeezing it as the

unfolded cross swirls in response, the surface bubbling. Eventually we find a direction to push that flattens all of the bubbles, so we hollow out a cone there and fall into it, landing back on the unfolded cross, but this time pushed along a magical vector field that feels effortless. Meanwhile, cut away from the sharp folded cross, we are free along the smooth part of the torus to decompress and unstretch back to what feels right.

We vibrate more slowly, and the ripples through us feel more linear, constrained to preset pathways, converging along invisible lines through the sea. The bursts of energy grow so extreme that they feel like discrete, isolated events, not fluctuations in a field of potentials. We each notice and remember them individually, using the information to bend and push future bursts up the energy gradient. Though we have our own memories and develop our own responses, we are all trying to solve the same problem, and the stream of discrete energy bursts is so continuous that our habits converge to form a single machine that notices, remembers, and updates. At some point I realize I am this machine, conscious again.

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Rust is on his feet and sprinting away, neck hunched and gait wobbly. My body feels unfamiliar, and I have to concentrate on putting one foot in front of the other, following at a distance.